

Comitatives as pseudo-verbs in Ch’ol

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1. Introduction

In this paper, I present new data from fieldwork on the comitative construction in the Mayan language Ch’ol, such as in (1). Cross-linguistically, comitatives are typically treated as adjuncts. In Ch’ol, however, what I call the “two-place comitative” patterns like a pseudo-verb: it licenses both external and internal arguments, and in many respects behaves like a transitive predicate. This parallels descriptions of comitatives in the Mayan language Tsotsil (Haviland, 1981), but contrasts with other Mayan languages such as Chuj (Buenrostro, 2009) and Tseltal (Polian, 2013), where only one argument may be indexed. The boxed morphemes in (1) index the first person subject and the bolded morpheme indexes the second person comitative participant.¹

- (1) Tsajñi[-yoñ] [k-]ik’oty-**ety**.
 go.PFV A1-with-B2
 ‘I went with you.’

Empirically, I show that Ch’ol comitatives share morphosyntactic properties with transitive verbs. They can index both a set A (ergative/possessor) and a set B (absolutive) argument, they exhibit variable agreement parallel to transitive predicates, and there are distinct semantic roles to their arguments. At the same time, they differ from true transitive verbs in that they cannot appear with verbalizing morphology or aspectual markers. I therefore adopt Haviland (1981)’s label by describing them as pseudo-verbs.

The agreement patterns of Ch’ol comitatives are not only significant within Mayan linguistics but also contribute to the broader typology of complex predicate formation. In particular, variable agreement with comitatives and verb–verb sequences in Ch’ol resembles well-documented restructuring environments in Romance and Germanic languages, where clitic climbing (Rizzi, 1982; Cinque, 2006) and long passives (Wurmbbrand, 2001, 2004) reveal porous clause boundaries. An example of these constructions in Ch’ol is shown in (2) where the parentheses indicate that the main predicate may optionally appear with the first person marker. Ch’ol thus provides novel evidence from Mayan that pseudo-verbal constructions may give rise to restructuring-like effects cross-linguistically (see also Wurmbbrand & Roberts (2010)).

- (2) Variable agreement
- a. Intransitive verb–comitative
 Ta’ jul-i(-yoñ) [k-]ik’oty-ety.
 PFV arrive-IV-B1 A1-with-B2
 ‘I arrived with you.’
- b. Intransitive verb–transitive verb
 Ta’ tyil-i(-yoñ) [j-]k’el-ety.
 PFV come-IV-B1 A1-with-B2
 ‘I came to see you.’

Theoretically, I argue that the availability of two-place comitatives in Mayan languages is tied to the distinction between high-absolutive (high-ABS) and low-absolutive (low-ABS) Mayan languages. In

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¹Glossing conventions: A = set A marks ergative and possessive; B = set B marks absolutive; CLF = classifier; EMPH = emphatic particle; DEF = definite; EXCL = exclusive; IMP = imperative; INCH = inchoative; IPFV = imperfective aspect; IV = intransitive verb; MASC = masculine; NML = nominalizer; PFV = perfective aspect; PL = plural; PREP = preposition; PROG = progressive aspect; TV = transitive verb

low-ABS languages like Ch'ol and Tsotsil, absolutive arguments are licensed low in the clause, allowing the comitative to pattern like a pseudo-verbal predicate with set B agreement. By contrast, high-ABS languages such as Chuj lack this option, correctly predicting the absence of two-place comitatives in those languages.

The goals of this paper are the following:

1. To document and analyze the two-place comitative in Ch'ol as a pseudo-verbal predicate with argument-structural and agreement properties parallel to transitives; and
2. To propose that the comitative's distribution is not accidental but predicted by the high-ABS/low-ABS distinction, with broader implications for the understanding of argument licensing and restructuring phenomena cross-linguistically.

The paper is structured as follows. Section 2 provides relevant background on Ch'ol. Section 3 presents the empirical generalizations on the two-place comitative, comparing them to transitive verbs with respect to argument licensing, agreement, semantics, and morphosyntactic restrictions. Section 4 develops the theoretical implications of the high-/low-ABS distinction for the distribution of two-place comitatives. Section 5 concludes.

2. Background on Ch'ol

Ch'ol is a Mayan language spoken by 254,000 people according to the 2020 census (INEGI, 2020) up from 215,000 from 2010, and between 100,000 and 200,000 cited in Juan Jesús Vázquez Álvarez's 2002 thesis Vázquez Álvarez (2010). Despite growing numbers, like any minoritized language, its position is precarious. The data collected here are from published sources and fieldwork in San Miguel, Chiapas, Mexico with speakers of the Tumbala dialect. I would like to especially thank Shenja Arcos Álvaro and Celia Álvaro Méndez for discussion of these data. Any uncited data has been elicited.

Ch'ol, like other Mayan languages, is ergative-absolutive, predicate initial, and head-marking language (see England (1991); Aissen et al. (2017) for properties of Mayan languages and Vázquez Álvarez (2011) for Ch'ol). Agreement for internal and external arguments indexed on verb. Examples in (3) show Ch'ol's alignment system with the perfective aspect marker *ta'*. (4) exemplifies verb-initial word order in Ch'ol. In (3-a), set B second person marks the subject of the intransitive, in (3-b) it marks the object of the transitive verb and the set A first person indexes the subject of the transitive verb. I use Mayanist labels for person markers: set B indicates absolutive arguments and set A indexes ergative and possessive arguments. Set B (absolutive) for third person is null and not included in the glossing. I simplify glosses to exclude certain verbal suffixes and name class prefixes *x* or *aj*.

- (3) a. Ta' majl-i-yety.
 PFV go-IV-B2
 'You left.'
- b. Ta' j-k'el-e-yety.
 PFV A1-see-TV-B2
 'I saw you.'
- (4) Ta' [_v i-kuchu] [_o si'] [_s xRosa]
 PFV A3-carry wood Rosa
 'Rosa carried wood.'

Having established the relevant background on argument marking and agreement in Ch'ol, I now turn to the comitative construction itself. While comitatives are often analyzed cross-linguistically as adjuncts, in Ch'ol they show unexpected predicate-like behavior. In what follows, I present diagnostics that demonstrate the pseudo-verbal nature of the two-place comitative.

3. Ch'ol two-place comitative

Below I show that, while the two-place comitative patterns like nominalized transitive verbs in many respects, it is unlike a verb in that it cannot appear with any verbal morphology or aspect markers. As

such, I conclude that the comitatives are “pseudo-verbs”, a label from Haviland (1981) who describes a similar construction for Tsotsil.

3.1. Morphology and person marking

The naturally occurring and elicited examples in (5) show instances of comitatives where two arguments are marked. In both of these examples the set A prefix (in boxes) indexes an argument of the main predicate: the subject of the intransitive verbs. The set B person marker (bolded) indexes the comitative participant.

- (5) a. $\tilde{N}ujpu\tilde{n}$ -eñ [aw-ik’oty-**oñ**] o mi a-bäk’ñañ a-mäk’lañ-oñ
 marry.IV-IMP.2 A2-with-B1 or IPFV A2-fear A2-support-B1
 ‘Marry me or are you afraid of supporting me’²
- b. Tsajñi -yoñ [k-ik’oty **xWañ**].
 go.PFV A1-with Juan
 ‘I went with Juan.’

The morphology of the comitative in these cases parallels that of transitive verbs. An example is shown in (6) where both set A and set B are indexed.

- (6) Mi k-mek’-ety.
 IPFV A1-hug-B2
 ‘I hug you.’

This parallelism already suggests that the comitative is more than an adjunct construction, since it supports the same argument-indexing strategy as core transitive predicates.

In contrast to Ch’ol, other Mayan languages such as Chuj (Q’anjob’alan), Chontal and only index one argument. An example from Chuj is shown in (7) where the comitative participant is indexed via set A marking.³

- (7) ix-ja winh [**w-et’ok**]
 PFV-come CLF.MASC A1-with
 ‘He came with me.’ Chuj (Buenrostro, 2009:58)

Tseltal, a closely related Mayan language to Ch’ol, does not index two arguments on the comitative either (Polian, 2013). The closely related Chontal language seems to pattern like Tseltal and uses the preposition *t’ok* plus an overt DP or pronoun (Osorio Mayo, 2016:184). Tsotsil, however, does have a two-place comitative construction, as in the bracketed constituent in (8).

- (8) Ja’ [a-chi’uk-**on**] tal.
 EMPH A2-with-B1 come
 ‘You were with me (when you came).’⁴ Tsotsil (Haviland, 1981:291)

The morphological evidence already suggests that the two-place comitative behaves like a transitive predicate, since it can index two arguments. Beyond morphology, however, further support for its

²From the Facebook page ‘aprendamos “ch’ol” lengua indígena de chiapas’ <https://www.facebook.com/share/p/15QNCsCdzv/>

³Ch’ol does have a one-place comitative, similar to Chuj, shown below.

- (i) Tsjañi xWañ **k-**ik’oty.
 go.PFV Juan A1-with
 ‘Juan went with me.’

Unlike the two-place comitative, the one-place comitative indexes the comitative participant with set A marking. Because of space limitations I concentrate on the two-place comitative in this paper.

⁴From Spanish *Estabas conmigo (cuando veniste)*.

predicate-like status comes from agreement: comitatives participate in variable agreement patterns similar to those found in verb–verb complexes in Ch’ol. I turn to this next.

3.2. Variable agreement

The comitative in Ch’ol patterns like nominalized transitive verbs in that they both exhibit variable agreement with unaccusative verbs. For example, both (9-a) and (9-b) are possible. The difference in these lies in whether the unaccusative predicate, *juli* ‘arrived’, appears with set B first person.

(9) Variable agreement with the two-place comitative

- a. Ta’ jul-i k- ik’oty-ety.
PFV arrive-IV A1-with-B2
‘I arrived with you.’
- b. Ta’ jul-i -yoñ k- ik’oty-ety.
PFV arrive-IV-B1 A1-with-B2
‘I arrived with you.’

The pattern with comitatives parallels that of transitive verbs. in (10), transitive verb ‘see’ indexes a first person subject and second person theme. Variable agreement is exhibited on the matrix verb, ‘come’: it may or may not agree with the first person subject.

(10) Variable agreement: Unaccusative verb – transitive verb

- a. Ta’ tyili j- k’el-ety.
PFV come A1-see-B2
‘I came to see you.’
- b. Ta’ tyil-i -yoñ j- k’el-ety.
PFV come-IV-B1 A1-with-B2
‘I came to see you.’

Note that when agreement appears on the main predicate, it must agree with in person and number with the highest argument of its complement, in this case first person, indexed by set A on the comitative. Agreement with the internal object, marked with set B morphology, is ungrammatical, as shown in (11).

- (11) a. *Ta’ jul-i -yety k- ik’oty-ety.
PFV arrive-IV-B1 A1-with-B2
Intended: ‘I arrived with you.’
- b. *Ta’ tyil-i -yoñ a- k’el--oñ.
PFV come-IV-B1 A1-with-B2
‘I came to see you.’

The variable agreement observed with verb–comitative and with the verb–verb sequences in Ch’ol suggests that these constructions share properties of clause union or complex predicate formation, familiar from restructuring environments cross-linguistically (e.g. Romance clitic climbing (Rizzi, 1982), German long passives (Wurmbrand, 2001)). In both (9) and (10), agreement can be realized on either the embedded predicate or the matrix predicate, showing that the boundary between them is syntactically porous.

The agreement facts demonstrate that comitatives share transparency effects with verb–verb complexes, reinforcing their predicate-like status. Agreement alone, however, does not establish whether comitatives behave like full verbs in terms of argument structure. To address this, I now turn to the semantics of comitatives, showing that there are distinct semantic roles to their two arguments in the same way as transitive verbs.

3.3. Semantic roles

Transitive verbs, needless to say, assign two different semantic roles to their arguments (e.g., agent and theme). If the comitative is like a transitive verb, then we would expect each argument indexed on it to have different semantic roles. This is in contrast to some languages, like Czech, where comitative phrases have the same semantic role, such as in (12), where Petr and little Marie, who is the comitative participant, both must be under the scope of agent-oriented adverbs.⁵

- (12) Petr s Maruškou neochtně pekli bábovku.
 Petr with little.Marie reluctantly baked.PL bunt.cake
 ‘Petr and little Marie reluctantly baked a bunt cake.’ Czech (Kučerová, *in prep*)
 Both Petr and little Marie must be reluctant, both underscope of agent-oriented adverb

I first establish that the Ch’ol comitative behaves like expected, only allowing for a collective reading (e.g., McNally (1993)), exhibited in (13) for Ch’ol. This is in contrast to conjunctive phrases, where both contexts would be possible.

- (13) Context A: I went to visit Juan’s house in the morning on Tuesday. You went to Juan’s house in the afternoon on Tuesday.

Context B: I went to visit Juan’s house in the morning on Tuesday. I brought you along.

Tsajñi-yoñ [k-]ik’oty-ety tyi y-otyoty xWañ tyi martes.
 go.PFV-B1 A1-with-B2 PREP A3-house J PREP Tuesday
 ‘I went with you to Juan’s house on Tuesday.’
 Context A ✗ Context B ✓

The contexts and examples in (14) with the inchoative verb *i’ik’-a* ‘to become tan’ exemplify that the comitative participant does not necessarily have the same semantic role as the predicate subject. The comitative participant does not need to have become tan, showing that it is not interpreted as sharing the predicate subject’s semantic role, but instead functions as an additional participant associated with the event; the addressee could have simply been there but their skin was unaffected by the sun.

- (14) Context A: You and I went to the beach. I got tan, but you did not.

Context B: You and I went to the beach. We both got tan.

- a. Ta’ i’ik’-a [k-]ik’oty-ety].
 PFV black-INCH A1-with-B2
 ‘I became tan with you.’ Context A: ✓; Context B: ✓
 b. Ta’ i’ik’-a -yoñ [k-]ik’oty-ety].
 PFV black-INCH-B1 A1-with-B2
 ‘I became tan with you.’ Context A: ✓; Context B: ✓

The comitative seems to be a general strategy in Ch’ol to introduce two arguments with different semantic roles. It can introduce the standard of comparison in (15).⁶

⁵Ch’ol comitatives are not so-called “plural pronoun constructions”. Plural pronoun constructions are possible in Tsotsil, exhibited in in (i) where it can be understood that the nominal introduced by the comitative participant is specifying who ‘we’ is in the group (the speaker and Xun).

- (i) Libat-otikotik [xchi’uk li Xune].
 go.PFV-1.PL.EXCL with DEF Xun
 ‘I went with Xun.’ (Two people only) Tsotsil (Aissen, 1989:519)
 Or ‘We went with Xun’ (Can be more than two)

⁶This is an innovation of the San Miguel variant of Ch’ol. Other speakers of Ch’ol reject the use of the comitative as introducing the standard of comparison and instead use *bajche* ‘how’ instead.

- (15) Ñumeñ chañ [-oñ] [k-] ik'oty-**ety** .
 more tall-B1 A1-with-B2
 'I am taller than you.'

Little & Toquero-Pérez (2026:18)

Certain psych-denoting predicates also appear with the comitative which can introduce the predicate subject and the theme of the experiencer, as in (16). The translations are from the speaker-provided Spanish *estoy enojada contigo*. In these cases, the comitative indexes the theme of the anger with set B and the experiencer with set A. The predicate below again displays an instance of variable agreement.

- (16) a. Mich' [-oñ] [k-] ik'oty-**ety** .
 angry-B1 A1-with-B2
 'I am angry at you.'
 b. Mich' [k-] ik'oty-**ety** .
 angry A1-with-B2
 'I am angry at you.'

The evidence from semantic roles confirms that the two-place comitative functions more like a transitive verb rather than a mere adjunct. At the same time, comitatives diverge from canonical verbs in their interaction with verbal morphology. This final diagnostic, below, further refines their status as pseudo-verbs.

3.4. The comitative does not appear with verbalizers and aspect markers

Unlike transitive verbs, two-place comitatives cannot appear with verbalizers nor can it appear with aspect markers. Transitive verbalizers in Ch'ol are glossed as TV and are vowel-harmonic with the root. An example with *chok* 'throw/send' is shown below with the perfective aspect marker *ta*'. Unlike transitive verbs, the two-place comitative cannot appear with any verbalizer as in (17-b).

- (17) a. **Ta**' k-chok-**o**-yety.
 PFV A1-throw-TV-B2
 'I sent you (somewhere).'
 b. ***Ta**' k-ik'oty-**o**-yety.
 PFV A1-with-TV-B2
 Intended 'I was with you.'

The comitative cannot be in the complement position of aspect markers, as shown in (18), compared to the transitive verb in (18-a).

- (18) a. Mi k-mek'-ety.
 IPFV A1-hug-B2
 'I hug you.'
 b. *Mi k-ik'oty-ety.
 IPFV A1-with-B2
 Intended: 'I am with you.'

In these respects, the comitative behaves akin to stative predicates, such as adjectives and nouns, which also disallow verbal and aspectual morphology in the language.

3.5. Summary

The diagnostics from Section 3 converge on the conclusion that the two-place comitative in Ch'ol is best analyzed as a pseudo-verb. It patterns like a transitive predicate in licensing arguments, showing variable agreement, and semantic roles yet diverges from canonical verbs in disallowing aspect and verbalizing morphology. A table summarizing the diagnostics and comparing them to transitive verbs is shown below.

	Set A	Set B	Variable agreement	Two semantic roles	Aspect markers	Verbalizing morphology
Transitive verbs	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Two-place comitative	✓	✓	✓	✓	✗	✗

Having established its pseudo-verbal status, the next question is why such a construction is available in Ch’ol but absent in closely related Mayan languages. In Section 4, I argue that this distribution follows from the high-/low-absolutive distinction.

4. Implications for the high-ABS/low-ABS distinction

4.1. High ABS and low ABS Mayan languages

Recall that the Mayan language Chuj only has the one-place comitative (7) where Ch’ol and Tsotsil have a two-place comitative. I propose that it is not accidental that the Mayan languages Ch’ol and Tsotsil have the two-place comitative while Chuj only has the one-place comitative. Taken together with observations about high-absolutive (high-ABS) and (low-ABS) Mayan languages, the possibility for a two-place comitative is only available to low-ABS languages like Ch’ol and Tsotsil and unavailable to high-ABS languages.

The terms high-ABS and low-ABS come from the descriptive observation that some Mayan languages’s set B (absolutive) markers appear high in the clause, while in other Mayan languages, set B absolutive markers appear low in the clause. The examples from Chuj and Ch’ol, (19), exhibit this with the set B absolutive markers bolded.

- (19) Position of set B markers (Royer & Coon, 2025:2)
- a. Ta’ a-mek’-**e-yoñ**.
PFV A2-hug-TV-B1
‘You hugged me.’ Ch’ol, low-ABS
- b. Ix-**in**-a-chela’.
PFV-B1S-A2S-hug
‘You hugged me.’ Chuj, high-ABS

As noted in, e.g., Coon et al. (2014, 2021), Royer (2022), and Royer & Coon (2025), not only is this a morphological difference, but the two types of languages display different *syntactic* properties as well. For example, high-ABS languages ban extracting ergative arguments, called the Ergative Extraction Constraint (Aissen, 2017; Coon et al., 2014, 2021). The extraction restriction is exhibited in (20), where ergative arguments cannot undergo A’ movement in Q’anjob’al, but can in Ch’ol.⁷

- (20) a. Maktxel_i max y-il-a’ _i ix ix?
who ASP A3-see-TV CLF woman
Intended ‘Who saw the woman?’ Q’anjobal (Coon et al., 2014:193)
(grammatical as ‘Who did the woman see?’)
- b. Majki ta’ y-il-a _i x’ixik?
who PFV A3-see-TV woman
‘Who saw the woman?’
(also grammatical as: ‘Who did the woman see?’)

This has led researchers in Mayan linguistics to posit different structures for the licensing of absolutive arguments. High-ABS and low-ABS Mayan languages vary in which functional head licenses the complements of verbs, the absolutive argument. In low absolutive languages, the licensor of the set B argument is *v*. However, in high absolutive languages, the licensor is T/INFL. In these languages, *v* has an EPP feature, triggering movement of the internal argument to the outer specifier of *v* so that it is

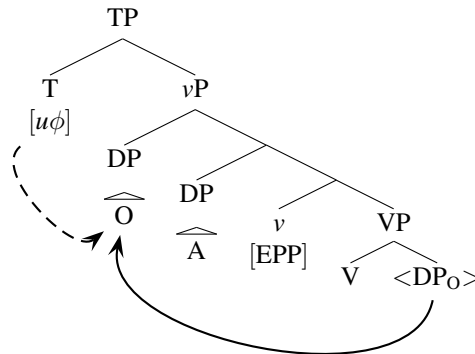
⁷The agent focus construction is needed in order to express the intended question in (20-a). See Coon et al. (2014, 2021) for details.

visible to T. This movement traps the external argument in the v making it inaccessible for A' extraction. No such configuration happens in low-ABS languages, so A' extraction proceeds as expected.

(21) Set B licensors in two types of Mayan languages

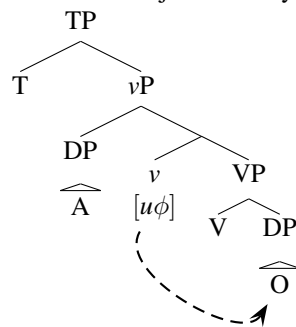
a. High ABS: Obj moves over subject and licensed by T

E.g. Chuj



b. Low ABS: Obj licensed by v

E.g. Ch'ol



One prediction of (21) is the variability of licensing set B arguments in non-finite clauses (Royer & Coon, 2025). In Low ABS set B is available in non-finite embedded transitives since T is not needed to license set B, shown in the bracketed clause in (22-a). In high ABS languages set B is *not* available in nonfinite embedded transitives, shown in (22-b).

(22) a. K-om [j-käñ-ety].
A1-want A1-know-B2

‘I want to know you.’

Ch'ol

b. *Ix-in-yamoch [hach-in-chel-a'].

PFV-A1-begin B2-A1-hug-TV

Intended ‘I began to hug you.’

Chuj (Royer & Coon, 2025:ex 29)

4.2. The two-place comitative and absolutive markers

The availability of the licensing of set B in Ch'ol is connected to the fact that comitatives also license set B via a similar mechanism, and is always non-finite. Set B is licensed low in Ch'ol and therefore it would not be expected that a high-ABS Mayan language develop a two-place comitative strategy like Ch'ol's. I thus propose the following implication:

(23) Comitative implication in Mayan

Two-place comitatives are possible only in low-ABS Mayan languages.

This is a one-way implication: the low-ABS structure provides the necessary conditions for a two-place comitative, but it does not guarantee their existence. Indeed, Tseltal, a low-ABS Mayan languages does not have a two-place comitative. The implication means that they would only be possible in low-ABS languages, but would be predicted to be banned in high-ABS Mayan languages. The availability of

the comitative as a pseudo-verb depends on how absolutive arguments are licensed (v vs T), providing independent support for the structural distinction argued for in Coon et al. (2014, 2021), Royer (2022), and Royer & Coon (2025).

5. Conclusions

In this paper, I have argued that the Ch'ol two-place comitative patterns as a pseudo-verb: it licenses both external and internal arguments, displays variable agreement similar to other verb–verb structures, and there are distinct semantic roles to its arguments. At the same time, it diverges from canonical verbs in not appearing with aspect markers or verbalizing morphology. This hybrid behavior motivates analyzing comitatives as pseudo-verbal elements.

A central empirical contribution has been to show that variable agreement with comitatives parallels the agreement patterns of verb–verb sequences in Ch'ol, where agreement can surface on either the embedded predicate or the matrix predicate. These porous clause boundaries are similar the clause union and restructuring phenomena well-documented in Romance and Germanic. In Italian and other Romance languages, clitics originating in the embedded clause may climb to the matrix verb (Rizzi, 1982; Cinque, 2006), while in German, long passives provide evidence that the object of an embedded infinitive may be licensed by the matrix predicate (Wurmbrand, 2001, 2004). Ch'ol thus adds to the growing body of cross-linguistic evidence that restructuring and complex predicate formation are not limited to Indo-European, but also arise in unrelated families such as Mayan (see also Wurmbrand & Roberts (2010)).

Theoretically, I have proposed that the availability of two-place comitatives in Ch'ol is tied to the low-ABS profile of the language. Since set B arguments in Ch'ol are licensed low in the clause (by v rather than T), comitatives can exploit this same low-licensing mechanism. By contrast, high-ABS languages such as Chuj lack this option, correctly predicting the absence of two-place comitatives in such languages. This result provides novel support for the high-/low-ABS distinction and suggests a new typological implication: two-place comitatives are predicted to be possible only in low-ABS Mayan languages.

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